

Expert Q&A;: Exercising Through a Flare-Up

When to push and when to rest.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-17 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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When to push and when to rest.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Versus Arthritis consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- **Talk to your clinician.** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- **Track your symptoms.** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- **Move within comfort.** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]/\(arthritis-flare-ups\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Systematic reviews of physical activity in inflammatory arthritis consistently show that regular, moderate exercise is not only safe but beneficial, even during periods of increased disease activity. These reviews, which pull together findings from many individual randomised trials, indicate that tailored exercise programmes can reduce pain, improve physical function, and enhance quality of life without worsening inflammation.

Clinical guidelines from professional bodies universally recommend that people with arthritis remain as active as possible, adapting their exercise routine during flare-ups rather than stopping altogether. The evidence suggests that complete rest for extended periods can actually be detrimental, leading to muscle weakness, joint stiffness, and a poorer long-term outlook.

Emerging research, including observational studies, further supports the idea that understanding your body's signals and adjusting activity levels accordingly is key. This 'listen to your body' approach, guided by health professionals, helps maintain conditioning and mental well-being, both crucial for managing long-term conditions.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Pushing through sharp pain:** Pain is a warning sign; ignore it at your peril. *Fix: Reduce intensity or stop the activity immediately.*

* **Stopping all movement entirely:** Complete inactivity can cause stiffness and weakness. *Fix: Opt for gentle, non-weight-bearing exercises like stretching or swimming.*

* **Increasing activity too quickly after a flare:** This can trigger a relapse. *Fix: Gradually reintroduce activities, increasing duration and intensity slowly over days or weeks.*

* **Ignoring new or worsening symptoms:** Changes might indicate a need to adjust treatment. *Fix: Document new symptoms and discuss them with your healthcare provider.*

* **Skipping warm-ups and cool-downs:** These prepare your joints and muscles. *Fix: Always include 5-10 minutes of gentle warm-up and cool-down stretches.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

While it's often possible to manage exercise during a flare-up with careful self-monitoring, there are times when it's important to seek advice from your GP, physiotherapist, or

rheumatologist. They can help rule out other issues, adjust your medication, or provide a revised exercise plan tailored to your current symptoms.

* Sudden, severe, or unexplained pain. * New or rapidly worsening joint swelling that doesn't subside. * Fevers, chills, or a general feeling of being unwell (systemic symptoms). * Significant unexpected weight loss. * Persistent pain or fatigue that doesn't improve with rest or adjusted activity.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can exercise make my flare-up worse? When done carefully and gently, exercise during a flare-up is unlikely to make it worse. The key is to listen to your body, reduce intensity, and focus on gentle movement rather than strenuous activity. Avoiding complete immobility can prevent stiffness and muscle loss.

What types of exercise are best during a flare-up? Low-impact activities like gentle stretching, swimming or hydrotherapy, tai chi, or slow walking are often recommended. These types of exercise help maintain joint mobility and muscle strength without putting undue stress on inflamed joints.

How do I know if I'm doing too much? Pay attention to increased pain, swelling, or fatigue within an hour or two after exercising, or the next day. If these symptoms are significantly worse, it's a sign you may have pushed too hard and should reduce the intensity or duration next time.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about expert q&a: exercising through a flare-up?

Short answer: During an arthritis flare-up, the article advises adapting rather than stopping exercise: keep gentle, regular, low-impact movement within comfort, track symptoms, and avoid pushing through sharp pain or increasing activity too quickly. It says guidance and reviews support combined medication, movement and lifestyle support, while new swelling,

fever, rapid functional loss or severe symptoms need clinician review.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk